To obtain a primary handwriting sample for **Thomas (Tom) J. Riese**, the **1956 Grantor/Grantee records** for the "Black House" sale at 6114 California Street are the most reliable legal source.

1. Locating the Signature on the 1956 Deed
While **Paul Ernest Riese** was the primary owner, Thomas may have signed as a witness, an officer of the family syndicate, or as the "Attorney-in-Fact" if he handled the transaction for his uncle.

- **Source:** Visit the San Francisco Assessor-Recorder's Office at **City Hall, Room 190**.
- **Search Parameters:** Search the **1956 Grantor Index** under "Riese, Paul E" or "Riese, Thomas J." Request a copy of the **recorded deed** (not just the abstract).
- **Handwriting Value:** Deeds from this era often include handwritten names and dates in the notary section or the "return to" address field.

2. Identifying "Zodiac" Handwriting Markers
If you obtain a signature or handwritten notes from Tom Riese from the 1950s or 60s, forensic document examiners typically look for the following "Zodiac" traits:

- **Checkmark 'r's:** The Zodiac had a distinctive way of writing a lowercase 'r' that looks like a checkmark.
- **The '3-Stroke' M:** A specific stutter in the formation of capital letters, particularly M and N.
- **Slant and Spacing:** The Zodiac's writing often had a slight erratic slant and wide spacing between words—common in someone used to filling out **property ledgers** or **engineering logs**.

3. Comparing to the "Early" Letters
The Zodiac's handwriting evolved over time. A 1956 sample from Tom Riese would be a baseline for his "natural" hand, which can be compared to:

- **The 1963 "Riverside" Letter:** If the handwriting matches a younger Riese, it would link him to earlier, pre-canonical crimes.
- **The 1969 "Stine" Letter:** This was written just after the murder in the neighborhood where Riese was most active.

Data Search Checklist for Handwriting

Document Source	Specific Data Point	Archive Location
1956 Sales Deed	Grantor or Witness Signature	SF Assessor-Recorder
1960s Voter Reg	Handwritten signature & address	SF Dept. of Elections
Building Permits	Project descriptions & Job Cards	DBI Records Management